

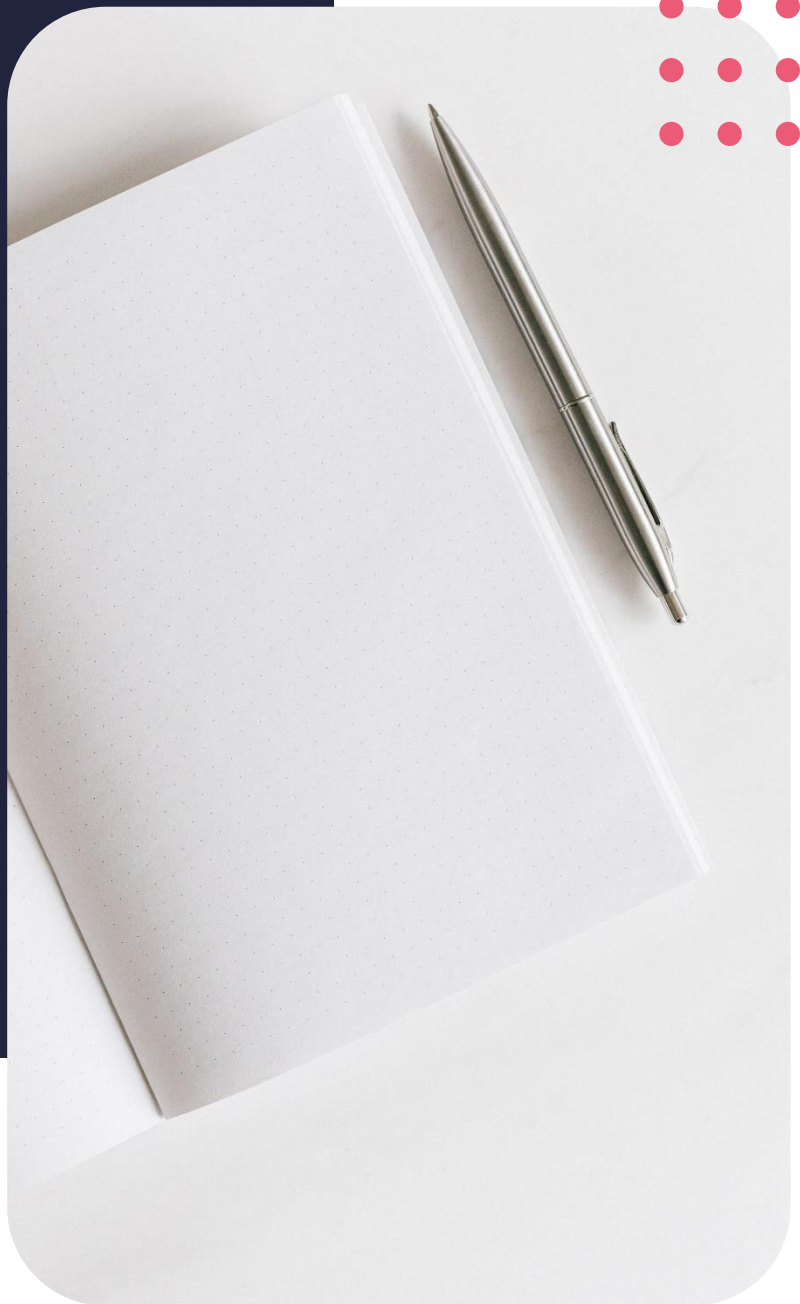
Diploma in Project
Management

Project Monitoring & Controlling



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Lesson objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Define monitoring and controlling
- Examine the ten phases of monitoring and controlling

Introduction

Welcome to lesson seven and today's lesson, we're going to be talking about project monitoring and controlling. I'd just like to quickly go through our objectives for today's lesson. And first, we're going to be talking about monitoring and controlling and 10 different phases that fall into this process.

Monitoring and controlling

So you've now executed your project. Hopefully everything has gone to plan and now we're going to monitor it and make sure that everything continues to go well. So it's ensuring that project objectives are met. And you do this by monitoring and measuring your progress regularly. And this allows you to then identify any variances from the plan. In other words, it'll let you know if something's going wrong and then you can take corrective action before anything else goes wrong.

Monitoring and controlling is a main function of a project manager. Both feature throughout the planning & execution phase of a project. It can only be effective if applied throughout the process. It can be useful to note points on the project plan, especially after milestones.

The ten steps of monitoring and controlling

Let's unpack the different tasks involved in the monitoring and controlling process. They are:

1. Project work
 2. Integrated change control
 3. Scope verification
 4. Scope control
 5. Schedule control
 6. Cost control
 7. Quality control
 8. Control risks
 9. Performance reporting
 10. Managing stakeholders
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Project work

Let's break these down further so no one monitoring and controlling project work when monitoring and controlling project work, you will need to take the following things into consideration. Firstly, when something does go wrong, what are your corrective actions going to be? Secondly, how are we going to prevent these risks or actions from happening in the first place? What can be forecasted or predicted? So how can we ensure that we know when something is going to go wrong so we can stop it from happening? Then you'll have your recommended defect repair. So if this does go wrong, how are we going to fix it and evaluate requested changes that have occurred during the execution phase?

Integrated change control

Second, we have integrated change control, and these outputs are going to include approved change requests, in other words, changes that have gone through the process we spoke about in lesson five. And they've now been implemented into a project. And now you need to make sure that the change is doing what it was designed to do.

You need to ensure that no rejected change requests have come through into the monitoring phase. You need to update your project management plan. And also, your SEO plan, we also project scope statement to make sure that all of the requirements have been met and any additional requirements have been met.

Scope verification

Then we have scope verification. And the process here would be to re-evaluate the project plan. In other words, the timeline, cost and scope that you agreed upon looking at the scope management plan and also evaluating your work breakdown structure. Remember that your work break down structures made up of your summary tasks, your subtasks and your work packages. Now, remember, within scope verification, acceptance will be given in terms of the project deliverables and goals from the clients. In a formal setting, you will get formal acceptance of the product or service that you've delivered in order to ensure that the client can never protest that you have not delivered on the requirements that they gave you.

Scope control

Once you've completed that, you'll move on to scope control. Now, within scope control, you will manage and control any changes within your project scope. So if something is taken longer than initially planned, you will need to monitor and make sure that your other other targets or milestones will still be met. Remember that these changes will have been through the change control process and time and costs would have already been estimated. So you just need to ensure that you are sticking to these estimations as closely as possible. Remember, again, in the scenario that you want to under promise and over deliver, it is important as a project manager to ensure that the vital success factors are achieved before the addition of nice to have elements. Now you're nice to have elements is also a thing called the bells and whistles. You need to make sure that the core requirements of your project work. Only once that's happened should you make it look pretty or add an extra functionalities that aren't key to your project.

What presents the highest risk for project failure? Well, as I'm sure all of you remember, it is scope creep. Scope creep is a project managers worst nightmare. How are we going to avoid scope creep where we're going to do schedule control and within schedule control? We're going to ensure that all deadlines within the project plan are being met.

Schedule control

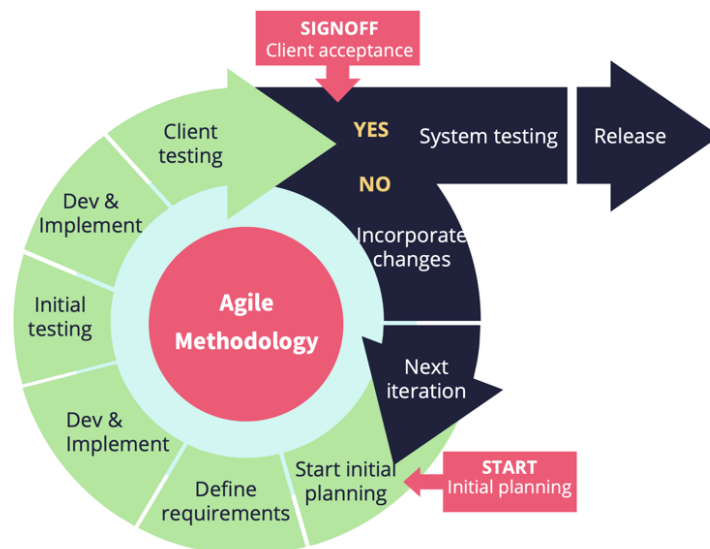
So we are going to monitor these elements within our gunshot and make sure that we are on schedule. This is going to include monitoring any approved changes, any risks that have come to life, and also our task statuses which we can track using Wragge, which is our Red Amber Green Review. The project baseline will then be evaluated to establish that the project is on track, your baseline being your predicted timeline within your project.

It's key to notice early on if you're going, of course, so that you can take corrective measures. And this process can also involve the reprioritisation of tasks, reviewing different work progress and managing approved changes.

One way to track all of this is to have status meetings, reports and updates. And the purposes of these meetings are to receive scheduled updates of project activities. In other words, to check in and see that everyone is on schedule. You can measure your project baseline against actual results so you can evaluate how long you thought things were going to take versus how long they've actually taken. And that can then allow you to update your project plan where necessary in order to ensure you've finished your project on time. It'll help you evaluate any potential risks that may arise and help you to decide whether you would like to try and avoid these risk altogether or take on one of your other risk approaches that allow status updates on budgets and quality.

This is quite a handy way to notice if you're going over budget at all or if money is starting to disappear and then your team may also be updated on the next steps. So once you've successfully finished a phase within your project or a milestone within your project, you can then inform the team on what is still to come. This information once it's been gathered and consolidated, will be presented to the key stakeholders in your stakeholder meetings or your state status checks with your stakeholders, and remember, you need to take into account their interests and influence what you can then track and your stakeholder register so you can see how frequently they should be receiving emails regarding this information.

A quick stop halfway through the ten steps of monitoring and controlling to check if you remember what these two diagrams represent? You saw them in the first lesson of this course - if that helps as a clue...



Of course, they are the Agile and waterfall project management methodologies. The Waterfall methodology is the more traditional linear approach that starts with defining your requirements. The Design phase is broken up into logical design sub-phases. The Implementation phase is bringing the design to life!

In the Verification phase, the customer reviews the project to make sure that it meets all the requirements that were laid out in the requirements phase.

This is when you would hand over the product or the project to the customer for them to check. The final phase is maintenance.

Agile is the more modern, flexible approach to project management. It is an iterative methodology that incorporates a cyclic and collaborative process. It involves constant collaboration with stakeholders and continuous improvement at every stage. Once the work begins, teams cycle through a process of planning, implementing, and evaluating.

Cost control

Back to our ten steps to monitoring and controlling. Step six that outlines cost control. Now, cost control is the process of overseeing costs throughout the project and managing your overall project budget. In other words, you would need to sign off on all expenses within your project and make sure that you're sticking to the budget that you agreed upon. It also allows for the opportunity to identify ways that you can reduce expenses within the project and which you can then use to increase your overall profit. So as the project manager, you need to try and identify things that can be streamlined. In other words, if something takes less time than you are using a resource list, which then frees them up to do something else, which ultimately will speed up your project and then make you more profitable. It also involves accounting for financial risks that could arise. In other words, having money set aside for any risks that may influence your project's success. And having it there is almost your rainy day fund. If costs are not controlled, the project runs the risk of going over budget and ultimately not aligning with scope. If you go over budget, you will no longer have the resources that you need in order to finish your project scope. And that is when people start to cut corners and we all know how we feel as clients if we feel that someone has cut corners. So always try and avoid that at all costs.

Throughout the project execution phase, the volatile elements that are going to require attention and that is going to be the reliability of the cost baseline in relation to the actual cost. So what you've estimated the cost of the project will be versus what it is actually costing your company, the stakeholder involvement, involvement, and you want to draw on their experience because they will be subject matter experts in their own areas. And the input could be very valuable to your project and to your team. And there's also time investments in this can include unnecessary resource allocation. Other words, having an extra person on a team who's actually not doing any work or any unnecessary purchases. So if you've ordered too much of something and the rest is just sitting in a storage room, you need to keep these things in account to make sure that you are not wasting money. Also, the effectiveness of forecasting expenses. So you predicted expenses. How well have you forecasted those then?

Quality control

We've got quality control and the benefits of quality control. So that is going to be validating your deliverables, ensuring that you've met the requirements of your customer. You also need to make sure that you're meeting the requirements and expectations of your stakeholders. You also need to identify the cause of any poor quality that is being delivered within your project. In other words, find out where things are going wrong. And then you once you've identified what's going wrong, you also need to recommend corrective measures in order to bring it up to an acceptable quality. They need to find out where quality is slipping and go and fix it. Here's a key example of where you can draw on stakeholders who might have expertise in this particular area.

Control risk

Number eight, we need to control our risks. Risk control allows the project manager to respond using strategies and contingency plans that you have already planned. So when you've gone through the planning phase, you've done brainstorming, you've done evaluations, and you've identified different things that could possibly go wrong within your project. That's where you've decided if you'd like to mitigate except avoid or transfer your risk. And you've got it all beautifully put down in a document. So you know how to respond in the moment. This is going to lie to make a fast acting decision and eliminate the impact of this realised risk. So it happens. You already know what to do. You really know if you've got the funds to correct it. Everything is planned. You just need to set in motion.

Now, during this process of controlling risk, the following will be reviewed, the effectiveness of your risk responses. So how well did they work according to your initial plan, monitoring of potential additional risks? Has this risk set off any additional risks? And finally, evaluating what triggered this risk to occur? So you need to evaluate how well you responded, if it's caused any additional risks, and then evaluate what actually made it happen.

Performance reporting

Once all of that's done, you'll move on to performance reporting. So the content of your performance reports include but are not limited to a percentage of the work completed during the reporting period. The balance of work that still needs to be completed, different costs incurred during this reporting period and the balance of funds available as well as the balance of time available. You'll also need to include the significant risks that have occurred or past without carrying. Essentially, what's happening during this process is they need to see over the period of time that your project has been running, how much work has been done, how much money have you spent? What is left within your project budget? How much time do you still have available to you? And any significant risks that have been flagged or any risk that you had prepared for that never came to be. Then there are also major remaining identified risks. These are risks that you have identified but have still not happened, but you'll still need to keep an eye on them.

Then there's also variance analysis which is going to compare your schedule variance and your cost. So how different was your initial time estimation and your initial budget estimation to what's actually happened then your performance indexes, which is going to be also how you perform and have you performed cost? Was the forecast funds required to complete the remaining work? And this will also include the full cost of funds required to complete any outstanding work. So how much money do we still need to put into this project in order to finish it? And then a summary of major approved change requests during the reporting period. In other words, during reporting, you need to just evaluate your time and your costs in relation to your initial estimates.

Managing stakeholders

Then the last thing you need to do on the cost management plan is go ahead and manage your stakeholders. So once plans are in place, it's onto the project execution, following these steps can put you on the right track for success. So you want to engage your stakeholders. Remember, it's better to overcommunicate than to assume that your stakeholders are on the same page as you, you want to use your analysis of stakeholders influence and interest to achieve a good balance of interaction. Remember, we spoke about this earlier on and the lesson and your key stakeholders should be closely involved with business decisions, whereas other departments may require less involvement. Remember, the more they know, the more they can help you.

So how are we going to go about managing these stakeholders? Well, you want to gain feedback and refine your approach. So the biggest determining factors for fictive stakeholder management are using their time and experience. You want to use this to your benefit? Following the steps laid out above and asked for feedback from your stakeholders, this can help you refine your perfect approach.

Conclusion

Which of the 10 phases of monitoring and controlling do you think is the most important? Now, there's no right or wrong answer here. It is your own opinion, but you can go ahead and type that into Morpheus. And if you'd like to justify your response and start a bit of a debate between the other students, you can also hashtag that actual project management and I can go and have a look as well. So which of the 10 phases of monitoring and controlling do you think is the most important?

Thank you so much for attending Lesson seven!
